If you don't grow this old-fashioned herb yourself, ask around among your gardening friends or head down to the nearest organic foods market to see if they sell it.

lovage soup

SERVES 4–6 **PREP** 10 MINS **COOK** 30 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS BEFORE CREAM IS ADDED

4 tbsp butter
1 onion, chopped
9–10oz (250–300g) floury potatoes, peeled and diced
1 large carrot, diced
a large handful of fresh lovage leaves
1¼ quarts (1¼ liters) chicken or vegetable stock
salt and freshly ground black pepper
6 tbsp heavy cream
cayenne pepper

1 Melt the butter in a large pan and add the onion, potato, carrot, and lovage. Stir, then cover and cook over low heat for 10 minutes.

2 Add the stock and a little salt and pepper. Bring to a boil and simmer for 15 minutes until all the vegetables are very tender. Cool slightly, process in a blender, and, if you would like a smoother soup, pass through a sieve. Taste and adjust the seasoning if necessary. Reheat when needed and stir in the cream. Serve with a dusting of cayenne pepper.

LOVAGE
When buying cut leaves, choose strong stems and yellow-green leaves, but remember that they don't keep for long. If you choose to grow your own, you will find that lovage can grow to a considerable height.

